

Customising Vista

Scratch the surface and you'll find that it's easy to personalise your copy of Vista – and give your computer a performance boost in the process. We show you how

Each fresh Windows Vista installation adheres to the default Microsoft settings and works perfectly well out of the box. But did you know that you can tweak and tailor virtually every aspect of Vista to suit your needs, preferences and personality? By experimenting with some of Vista's lesser-known settings and options, you can put your own stamp on your computer and, as we're about to find out, it's well worth doing so.

Settings for sounds, images, security, performance and much more can all be altered. Best of all, you don't need to be an expert user to get started – all that's required is a little bit of insider knowledge. Many options can be customised directly within Vista using standard Microsoft settings, but there are also plenty of third-party applications available that provide access to advanced tweaks and tools.

We'll take you through a selection of the best Vista customisation tips and tricks. Then it's on to the Workshops, where you can try them out for yourself.

Quick and simple tweaks



The Personalize tools offer a quick and easy way to start customising Windows Vista

The best way to start customising Vista is to right-click an empty part of the Desktop and select the Personalize option. The window that appears lists seven customisation tools, ranging from the appearance of your Desktop through to audio settings and screensavers.

If you want to make

a quick and radical change to Vista's appearance, the Theme option is definitely worth trying out. A Vista Theme is essentially a collection of settings that are all applied at once – these include the wallpaper, screensaver, sounds and even the style of the mouse cursor.

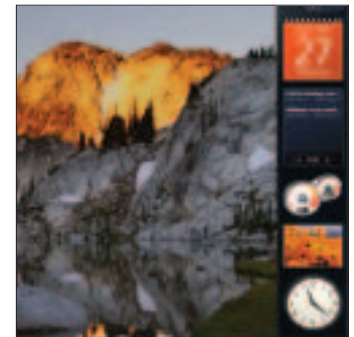
You can select one of the predefined Windows Themes or opt to browse for one on your hard disk. And you needn't spend ages creating your own if you don't want to as there are plenty available online free of charge. A quick internet search for 'Vista Themes' will give you a huge number of sites, with www.guimods.com and www.myvistathemes.com being two good examples.

Take a moment to look through the other options in the Personalize window; they're all self-explanatory, easy to use and simple to change back if you decide you don't like them.

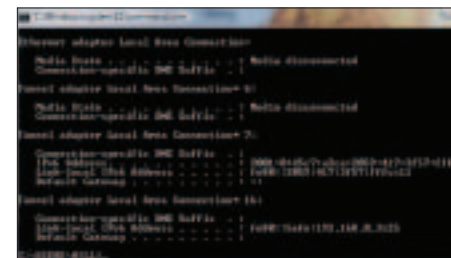
Bypass your mouse

Although Vista's point-and-click interface makes it easy to navigate with a mouse, it's often much quicker to use keyboard shortcuts instead. And should a battery-powered mouse run out of juice, these shortcuts provide you with the power to carry on working without it.

You can control almost every aspect of Vista using keyboard shortcuts. And, once you have mastered them, you'll find most are both easier and quicker



Vista's Sidebar can be customised to house your favourite Gadgets and mini programs



The no-nonsense Command Prompt tool can be extremely powerful and easy to use

than using your mouse.

Microsoft places great emphasis on Vista's sparkling interface, but there will be times when it's far quicker and easier to use something called the Command Prompt. Purely text-driven, the Command